The Echoes of Teachers

By Kevin M Derrig and Taylor Mali

INTRODUCTION

In Taylor Mali's unapologetic declaration, "What Teachers Make," teaching is not a fallback plan but a force -- measured not in salary, but in courage, curiosity, and lives changed.

However, Kevin M. Derrig's "First Period" shifts the lens, exposing what happens when teachers forget their responsibility. When red ink wounds deeper than it corrects, and a raised hand becomes a breaking point.

Teachers hold the power to build or to bruise, to ignite possibility or silence it. What happens in the classroom can echo for a lifetime.

The Echoes of Teachers with poems by Kevin M Derrig and Taylor Mali

What Teachers Make, or, Objection overruled, or
If things don't work out, you can always go to law school
by Taylor Mali

(Pgs 35-37) He says the problem with teachers is

What's a kid going to learn

from someone who decided his best option in life

was to become a teacher?

He reminds the other dinner guests that it's true

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what they say about teachers:

Those who can, do; those who can't, teach.

I decide to bite my tongue instead of his

and resist the temptation to remind the dinner guests

that it's also true what they say about lawyers.

Because we're eating, after all, and this is polite

conversation.

I mean, you're a teacher, Taylor.

Be honest. What do you make?

And I wish he hadn't done that

(asked me to be honest)

because, you see, I have a policy

about honesty and a**-kicking:

if you ask for it, then I have to let you have it.

You want to know what I make?

I make kids work harder than they ever thought they

could.

I can make a C+ feel like a Congressional Medal of Honor

and an A- feel like a slap in the face.

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How dare you waste my time with anything less
than your very best.

I make kids sit through 40 minutes of study hall
in absolute silence. *No, you may not work in groups.*
No, you may not ask a question.
Why won't I let you go to the bathroom?
Because you're bored, and you don't really have to go to the bathroom, do you?

I make parents tremble in fear when I call home:
Hello, this is Mr. Mali. I hope I haven't called at a bad time,
I just wanted to talk to you about something your son said today.
To the biggest bully in the grade, he said,
"Leave the kid alone. I still cry sometimes, don't you?
It's no big deal."
And that was noblest act of courage I have ever seen.

I make parents see their children
for who they are and what they can be.

You want to know what I make?

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I make kids wonder,
I make them question.
I make them criticize.
I make them apologize and mean it.
I make them write, write, write
and then I make them read.

I make them spell
definitely beautiful, definitely beautiful, definitely beautiful
over and over and over again until they will never misspell
either one of those words again.
I make them show all their work in math
and hide it on their final drafts in English.
I make them understand that if you've got *this*,
then you follow *this*,
and if someone ever tries to judge you
by what you make, you give them *this*!

Here, let me break it down for you, so you know what I say is true:
I make a god*** difference! What about you?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Taylor Mali
Book: What Learning Leaves, 2nd Edition
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Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): March 2013

NOTE: *Author grants use of his poetry for forensics competitions: "If you are looking for permission to perform one of my poems in forensic competition, consider it granted."*
https://taylormali.com/contact/seeking-permission/

First Period by Kevin M Derrig

(Pg 220-221) half way through first period
dust accumulated on the sweaty palm of my
raised hand
must be a centimeter thick by now
as the chicken-legged teacher goes around the
room
defacing students' homework from last night
with red pen graffiti
that focuses more on missed commas than the
content of the sentences
he finally decides to acknowledge me

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"Mr. Derrig, why do I have a feeling that this is
another one of your dumb
comments. You constantly waste my time. Why
don't you just drop out or something?"

why don't I just drop out
why don't I just drop out!

and it was at that moment that all statistics
began to make sense to me
statistics of children whose mouths water more
for the many taste of
society corner slanged penicillins
than the cardboard textures of diplomas
with pipes more important to fill
than class requirements
statistics of classes cut
to avoid battlefields full of aggravated shrapnel
from teachers with exploding tempers
teachers with magnifying glasses at the end
pointers
who feed off the brightness of surrounding
students

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to singe holes in the esteems of those who need
just a little more help
than
others

I wanted to turn my shot-down hand into a fist
I wanted to hit him 'til he was incapable of
speaking anymore
but I didn't want to become another number in
overflowing manila folders
of children arrested in school

and we wonder why a gun seems to fit perfectly
in the hands of this generation's adolescents

ladies and gentlemen
I'm writing this poem to highlight that which has
been stuck like gum
underneath wobbly desks
free from parental eyes
only to mess the hand of those who have to sit
there
I'm writing this poem to speak for all the rows of
children before me

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who remained voiceless in the cracks of school
and its sound proof textbooks
I'm writing this poem for all the children who
have not yet been named
the ones that will one day have to fill these rows
I've been struggling in
only to enter classrooms where they'll be shot
down for what they feel

ladies and gentlemen
the future of America is being crushed between
the molars
of power-hungry tyrants who think class rooms
are boot camps

and if we have any teachers in the audience
I urge you to understand that the hand you grab
the chalk with
the hand you grab those red pens with
the voices you speak with
are oversized chisels
and you must proceed to teach with caution
for what you say and what you do is written in

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stone

and if you chisel too hard these minds can crack

"So what don't you understand now, Mr. Derrig?"

I just wanted to know if I could go to the bathroom

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin M. Derrig
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution: Slam, Hip Hop & the Poetry of a New Generation; Pgs 220-221
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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
("First Period" as part of another collection)
IL State Qualifier
("First Period" as part of another collection)
KS State Qualifier – *(This collection)*

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